

ANIMALS IN DANGER

Common hippopotamus

⚠️ IUCN status: vulnerable

📊 Population estimate: 115,000–130,000

Pygmy hippopotamus

⚠️ IUCN status: endangered

📊 Population estimate: 2,000–2,500

KEY

🟠 Common hippopotamus

🟡 Pygmy hippopotamus

River hippo

In West Africa, the common hippopotamus lives along the banks of big rivers that wind through thick forest. Sometimes they even wander down to the sea.

AFRICA

Jungle hippo

The pygmy hippopotamus is found along densely forested streams, where it feeds on water plants and fruits that have fallen onto the forest floor. Loss of habitat threatens the couple of thousand that are left in the wild.

Hippos

No big land animal spends as much time in water as the hippopotamus. There are two species, and both live in Africa. During the day they wallow to protect their skin from the sun, with only eyes and nostrils breaking the surface.

Greasy skin

The skin oozes an oily liquid that acts as a sunscreen and antibiotic. As it dries, it can make the hippo look pinkish.

Gigantic jaws

A common hippopotamus has the biggest jaws of any land animal. Enormous, tusklike teeth are biggest in males, and are used as weapons in fights over females.



Common hippopotamus

Underwater moves

Despite its bulky body, the common hippo can move quickly through shallow water. Since its enormous head makes up 60 percent of the hippo's total weight, it relies on its trotting front legs to avoid toppling forward. Its dense bones keep the hippo weighed to the bottom, so it cannot swim freely in deeper water.

